

d.school 5-Stage Model

Empathise → Define → Ideate → Prototype → Test

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The d.school model organises human-centred design into five non-linear modes: **Empathise** (understand users), **Define** (frame the right problem), **Ideate** (generate options), **Prototype** (make ideas tangible) and **Test** (learn from users). Teams loop back freely rather than march straight through.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Codified by the Hasso Plattner Institute of Design at Stanford (the d.school), building on IDEO practice, from the mid-2000s.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Design thinking needed a teachable, memorable scaffold so that students and non-designers could apply human-centred methods without years of studio training.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW



Figure 1. d.school 5-Stage Model framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

HOW IT IS USED

Teams move through the modes on a real challenge, treating each as a mindset to enter rather than a box to tick, and iterating whenever testing reveals the problem was mis-framed.

WHEN IT IS USED

As the default process for any human-centred innovation project, and as the structural backbone of Units 3–9 of this course.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Design teams, educators, product managers and cross-functional innovation groups.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It made design thinking **learnable in days**, translating tacit designer craft into an explicit five-mode process — the most widely taught DT model in the world.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Double Diamond *Slibrary 3*

Desirability–Feasibility–Viability *Slibrary 3*

Empathy Map *Slibrary 5*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Plattner, H. (2010) *An Introduction to Design Thinking: Process Guide*. Stanford: d.school.

Brown, T. (2009) *Change by Design*. New York: Harper Business.